
Introduction

Transdisciplinary education is surprising, because it essentially re-asks the fundamental question: “*What is the purpose of our education?*” — and this becomes especially clear in the context of **assessment**.

A clearly measurable goal, a straightforward right or wrong, doesn't exist when working on wicked problems. So how do you assess? And: *who* do you assess, when students collaborate as equals with other partners in the project?

In a transdisciplinary setting, assessment can sometimes lead to tensions or uncertainties. The in-depth **Theory** page sheds light on the background of assessment and helps you find a place for it within a transdisciplinary module.

Theory

Assessment plays a central role in education: it helps guide learning, makes visible whether learning outcomes have been achieved, and is often necessary for earning credits or degrees. In transdisciplinary education, however, assessment brings additional challenges, because learning is highly **unpredictable, personal,** and **context-dependent**.

There is still little empirical research on assessment and evaluation in transdisciplinary education (Swanenberg, 2024). What is clear: **context is key**.

Always align with the learning outcomes and learning activities in your specific educational practice — there is no golden standard, but there *is* a need for careful consideration.

It's important to reflect on four fundamental questions:

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1. **Who assesses?**
 2. **What is the purpose of assessment?**
 3. **What do you assess?**
 4. **How do you assess?**

Who is involved in the assessment?

Transdisciplinary education is based on **equal collaboration** between students, teachers, practice partners, and sometimes even citizens. Yet, assessment in higher education is primarily focused on students. This **asymmetry** — only the student is assessed — can clash with the goal of equality in collaboration. Although little research is available on this, it's important to consciously consider the implications of assessment on interpersonal dynamics in your design (Meyer et al., 2025).

What is the purpose of assessment?

Instead of uniform learning goals for all students, transdisciplinary learning often focuses on **personal, professional, and identity development**. Students bring their own knowledge, experiences, and learning needs. Assessment should therefore allow for **diversity**: it should challenge students to grow, rather than limit them. This calls for **assessment for learning** (rather than assessment as a final checkpoint), and an approach that values differences between students

— known as “**assessment for distinctiveness**” (Jorre de St Jorre & Oliver, 2018).

What do you assess in transdisciplinary education?

Learning outcomes in transdisciplinary education often involve **integration of perspectives, dealing with complexity, reflection, and collaboration**. Such outcomes are not straightforward and often involve **learning surprises** (Baggen et al., 2022; Gulikers & Oonk, 2019).

It's therefore important to create clarity — together with students and stakeholders — about what is considered a **valuable result**, both in terms of content and process.

Three possible assessment domains:

- **Societal performance** – contribution to the issue or practice
- **Process accountability** – how the result was achieved
- **Personal development** – growth in collaboration, reflection, and ~~Personal development~~

How do you assess?

To align with the learning process in transdisciplinary education,

a **variety of assessment formats** is needed (Meyer et al., 2025).

Examples include:

- **Product-oriented assessment** (e.g., prototyping, portfolio, or substantive) and
- **Process-oriented assessment** (e.g., in-classroom, peer-review, or self-reflection) – visible

Tip:

This article shows how **Student-Devised Assessments** in interdisciplinary modules can radically change the way we learn and assess.

References:

Baggen, Y., Lans, T., & Gulikers, J. (2022). Making entrepreneurship education available to all: Design principles for educational programs stimulating an entrepreneurial mindset. *Entrepreneurship Education and Pedagogy*, 5(3), 347-374.

Gulikers, J., & Oonk, C. (2019). Towards a rubric for stimulating and evaluating sustainable learning. *Sustainability*, 11(4), 969.

Jorre de St Jorre, T., & Oliver, B. (2018). Want students to engage? Contextualise graduate learning outcomes and assess for employability. *Higher Education Research & Development*, 37(1), 44-57.

Meyer, H., Riva, E., Logan, F. et al. Humanising higher education through interdisciplinary student-devised assessments. Humanit Soc Sci Commun 12, 1196 (2025). <https://doi.org/10.1057/s41599-025-05513-4>

Practice

Transdisciplinary work is a process — and so is gathering and collecting knowledge about it. So far, there are still few ready-made tools for assessment in transdisciplinary education. More information will follow soon.

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***P.S.** Do you already have a tool, or have you recently come across new practical resources? Please let us know!*